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Designing participation for commoning in temporary spaces: A case study in Aveiro, Portugal

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Abstract: Western contemporary cities are investing in interactive spaces that promote passive participation through consumption. At the same time there are collaborative networks emerging in those urban areas enabling new forms of participation for the common good. One of the questions design research can raise is how design practices can assist in creating spaces that facilitate processes of commoning. This paper focuses on participatory processes in temporary spaces through the aesthetic experience. The concepts of "commons/commoning" and co-creation are examined from the perspective of Design for Social Innovation, Design Activism and Participatory Design. In this sense, this paper aims to critically analyse an experimental, interdisciplinary and cross-sectorial initiative setting up in a coastal urban community in Portugal. The project explored the possibilities to strengthen community relationships through design collaborations and encounters between different local capacities.

Keywords: common spaces, aesthetic experiences, collaborative initiatives, urban areas

Introduction

In post-industrial cities with economies targeted to the development of technological systems and services, the promotion of innovation through cultural activities is becoming a standard urban development strategy. Committed to attract creative minds, cities make their best to create an image of themselves as socially and culturally dynamic, a competitive model that also contributes to gentrification through the overvaluation of some urban areas at the expense of others. Consequently, cultural planning or the use of artistic practices may have negative consequences, such as the exclusion of a great part of the local population from innovation processes, or sustaining limited relationship based upon enclosure (Deutsche 1996; Mathews 2010).

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Parallel to innovation-oriented strategies, culture-driven micro-practices of management of urban spaces have emerged. These practices aim to solve everyday problems by stimulating horizontal decision-making processes, such as urban gardening or co-housing spaces. Different from innovation, these processes can be analysed in terms of "commoning", which opens up possibilities to experience new forms of urban co-creation and work with local resources for developing a collaborative culture (Seravalli 2014). Taking into account this process, the present study investigates how design can contribute to the mediating between current urban development strategies and initiatives of commoning.

Many design approaches have been developed to encourage public participation in innovation processes. In the Social Innovation field, design practices have emerged enabling users that adjust elements following progressive solutions (Manzini 2007). Design Activism takes this interaction a step further, exploring the potential for aesthetic practices in urban environments not only to affect people's perceptions but to actively change the power dynamics and allow for new ways to establish relationships and collaborations (Markussen 2013; Fuad-Luke 2012; Markussen 2013; Thorpe 2012). The Participatory Design discussion is moving from issues of 'democracy at work` to broader democratic matters of citizenship and public engagement (Björgvinsson, Ehn, and Hillgren 2012).

Therefore, this paper argues that for a community to cultivate creativity and develop a political culture of participation applied to daily collective challenges, it requires spaces that allow open collaborations among different local capacities. Thus, the main research question of this study concerns this spatial accommodation: How can design practices assist in creating spaces that facilitate processes of commoning and enable people to take part in social progressive change?

In this sense, this study is focusing on the interdisciplinary efforts of creating participatory processes through micro social practices in urban communities. It is an approach that also faces the transition to more sustainable cities from the socio-cultural perspective through changes of habits and worldviews. Consequently, it is a qualitative analysis of collaboration networks established during the development of a project of co-creation of a temporary common space in the Portuguese city of Aveiro. The paper intends to articulate the factors that enabled the activation of participation, including the local effects in terms of empowerment.

Section 2 explores the process in terms of commoning including the role of design research in the design for commoning. Section 3 presents the methodology and the collected evidences from the fieldwork. Section 4 points out the results and discussions. Finally, section 5 sets the conclusions.

Participation for commoning

Commoning process

The notion of “commons” refers to the collective use of natural resources of the planet claimed as common good for everybody through informal situations. It can also refer to resources that people share and do not need to pay for (Hardin 1968; Ostrom 1990). The concept is also discussed by De Angelis and Stavrides (2010) as a complex process of social production involving human knowledge, languages, social practices, forms of relationships, affectivity, etc. In this context, the political perspective of commons challenges the idea of development through the accumulation of capital and the increase of consumption. Instead, the notion of commons opens up new perspectives of collaborative practices as alternative ways of life, including alternatives for the development of a “sharing economy”, where every form of experience has an economic value independent of the rules of private corporations (Ostrom 1990).

In their analysis of present societal orders, Hardt and Negri (2009) also argue that the economic system itself creates conditions for the production of commons. The economy based on "immaterial labour" brought collaborative production of more sustainable livelihoods through an increased knowledge exchange in the virtual world. In spite of the fact that the authors identify a possible production of commons within the neoliberal system, they also point to the emergence of strong control mechanisms regulating the commons and thus also changing its political sense. These aforementioned changes are conducted by integrating commons as a subculture within the cultural hegemony, translating its meaning in a benevolent social practice, instrumental for perpetuating the neoliberal agenda (Hebdige 1979).

De Angelis (2010) points out three elements that characterize commons. First, every common involves necessary resources, which are not commodities such as natural supplies, mobility, housing and food, communication, etc. Second, commons are necessarily supported by communities that share resources and establish rules for its access and usability. These communities are not restricted to certain sites, but able to operate in multiple locations. They are also non-homogeneous in cultural terms. The third aspect is their groundedness in action. The “commons” is in this respect not a noun but a verb, *common-ing*, i.e. a continuous social process that creates and plays the commons (Linebaugh, 2008). Thus, resources, communities and continuous negotiations is what identifies commons and “commoning processes” (De Angelis and Stavrides 2010; Seravalli 2014).

In terms of the spatiality of commons, some questions are raised like the territorial dispute of power, the distribution of resources and the access to basic human rights. These issues reveal conflicts and are not welcome by current urban planning strategies, which advocate open spaces for the production of experiences within the limits of "colourful environments" directed for "cordial encounter" (Reimer 2011). In this sense, how can design contribute to

enhance situations able to ground transitional spaces where forms of negotiations are tested for processes of commoning?

Designing participation in design research

Participation as commoning is related to the collective construction of new forms of collaboration in which top-down decision structures are challenged. Participation in design is linked with co-creation that aims the progressive improvement of mutual learning between different stakeholders, from problem definition to the implementation of the design in real life (Fuad-Luke 2012). This field involves different emerging approaches in design practices and design research. This paper uses three concepts that might enable a deeper understanding of the design practice as commoning: *diffuse creativity, disruptive aesthetic and democratic innovation.*

First, in the field of Design for social innovation, common spaces are open fields for the exchange of experiences and worldviews, in this way facilitating solutions to the problems of everyday life. As spaces for exchanges, they must be built, activated and appropriated also through co-creation with different stakeholders. These spaces are essential to the promotion of a *"diffuse creativity"* fostered by communities through collaborative meeting cultures, facilitating the invention and managing of innovative solutions for new forms of urban life (Manzini 2007).

Second, Design activism research develops designedly ways of intervening in people's lives exploring the interference of material objects in the public sphere and in urban environments. Instead of entirely breaking with paradigms of traditional power, activist design projects use a *"disruptive aesthetic"* creating "contest, revelation and dissensus" from within the social order. Thus, from this point of view, it is in the intersection between the political and the aesthetic that it is possible to understand the effects of these practices on the daily life (Markussen 2013).

Third, the “design things” approach proposes a transition from understanding the innovation of a technocratic process led by experts and focused on the production of objects and services to a *"democratic innovation"* process motivated by the relationships established between the different actors involved, in which new opportunities are pointed out and explored. "Things" are recognized as socio-material assembly processes resulting from relevant issues located at a certain time through disputes between various stakeholders (Bjögvinsson et al. 2012). For the production of "things" it is by necessity of direct participation in the co-creation process. The invitation to participate in "democratic design experiments" is an active and delicate matter of proposing alternative possibilities to prompt curiosity and ambiguity, in order to activate the participants desire for interference (Binder, Brandt, Ehn, and Halse 2015).

The diagram below (Fig. 1) visualizes how these concepts previously presented are connected in this research. The concepts of design research — *diffuse creativity, disruptive aesthetic* and *democratic innovation* — are related to the three elements that identify

commoning process — *resources, communities* and *continuous negotiations*. Together, these concepts provide a preliminary analytical map for design participation for commoning.



Figure 1 Analytical map made by the authors.

The case study

The evidence sources were collected in the city of Aveiro, in June and October 2015. Aveiro is a city with 78.000 inhabitants being an important university and tourist town of Portugal (EU 2014). The studied project is called *Viva Cidade*, which means "Living City". It was one of the 10 selected projects in Europe forming part of the program “Actors of Urban Change” coordinated by the Cultural Foundation Robert Bosch. The purpose of the international program was “to achieve sustainable and participatory urban development through cultural activities” (Surwitto-Hahn and Schwegmann 2015). The application required the participation of three sectors of society (public, private and civil society) and included a budget of 10,000 Euros.

The core team of the *Viva Cidade* project consisted of: a representative of the City Hall of Aveiro working in the urban planning department; a director of a small enterprise working in the promotion of cultural and design projects; and a president of an Non Governmental Organization (NGO) founded by students of the Aveiro University, working within the field of social innovation. During the design process the team worked with professionals from the fields of design, arts, education, architecture and urban planning.

The project took place over 18 months between the autumn of 2013 and the summer of 2015 reaching about 250 people. It was carried out in a small space (around 15x8 metres) located in a residential neighbourhood, where of 20% of the residents are youths, most of them university students, 60% are adults and 20% are elderly people (INE 2011). The problem highlighted by the project was the distance between the academic and local community, beyond the lack of participatory channels between both the citizens and public

sector. Thus, one of the main objectives of the project was to promote the interaction between the university and the local community, building possible bridges of dialogue with the municipality and the local businesses.

The *Viva Cidade* project was chosen as a case study because it presents experimental strategies for designing participation for commoning in a small urban neighbourhood, as well as the fact that the project was proposed by a foreign cultural institution representing a top-down proposal. Moreover, it also brought a relevant design challenge experiencing micro scale strategies that could promote a neutral space in which negotiations occur between top-down and bottom-up perspectives. The project proposes the possibility of negotiations between the three sectors of society with a team of designers and non-designers.

Participant observation was used to collect data in the field. In order to map conflicts and challenges, qualitative interviews were carried out with representatives of the three sectors involved in the project. Moreover, qualitative questionnaires were applied to the local residents and contributors of the project in order to identify possible effects of the experience in their lives. The collected data was interpreted using the encoding method in order to connect the information and the commoning concepts in the analysis (Saldana 2009). In this sense, the codes revealed three categories of understanding: *engagement, collaboration and empowerment*. The figure below indicates in which stage of the project each category was more present. However, these categories are not linear and intersect each other during the process. Subsequently, the subsections describe the stages of the project before the analysis of each category in the next section.

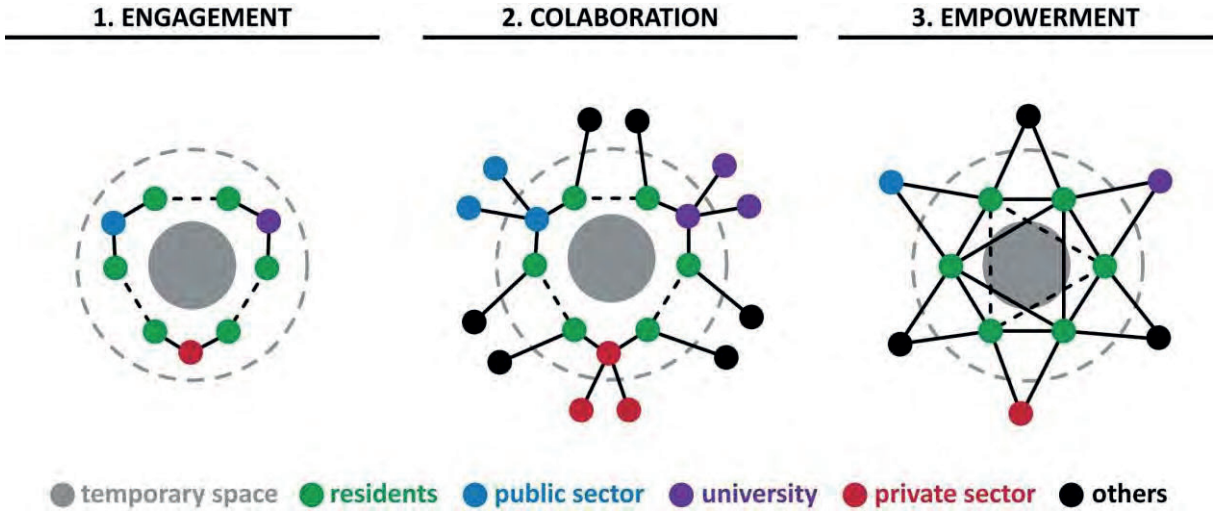


Figure 2 First stage, the core team started the activation of the participation process. Second stage, activating collaborations expanded the team. Third stage, the community was empowered through internal and external collaborations. "Others" refer the residents from outside of the neighbourhood. Diagram made by the authors.

First stage

This stage lasted one year when there was the process of engagement with both the local and university community towards the co-creation of a collective proposal, according to the following aspects:

Collection of memories: Collection of memories through storytelling of the elderly residents in one of the oldest neighbourhoods of the city.

Communicating: Mobilization process of the residents and the academic community through the creation of a visual identity, public presentations at the university and artistic interventions in the neighbourhood. Short videos with the memories of the neighbourhood were released in social networks and added to support local media that followed the entire project implementation.

Meetings and designing: Four meetings were held with residents, students and interested professionals. Each meeting brought together around 25 people. The meetings were carried out through participation methods (Fig. 3 and 4) that facilitated both the collective choice of the space and the co-creation of the final proposal that could gather the expectations of stakeholders. The final selected space was one of the City Hall properties, which was temporarily provided until the construction of a street already projected for this location. It was located in a central and visible area of the city, being a strategic space to test the methodology of the project.



Figure 3 "City Mapping: Flat the Spot!". Participants mapping the favourite and non-favourite spots of the neighbourhood with green and red flags. This technique allowed identifying ideas, desires, and collective concerns. Photo by Viva Cidade, commented by authors.

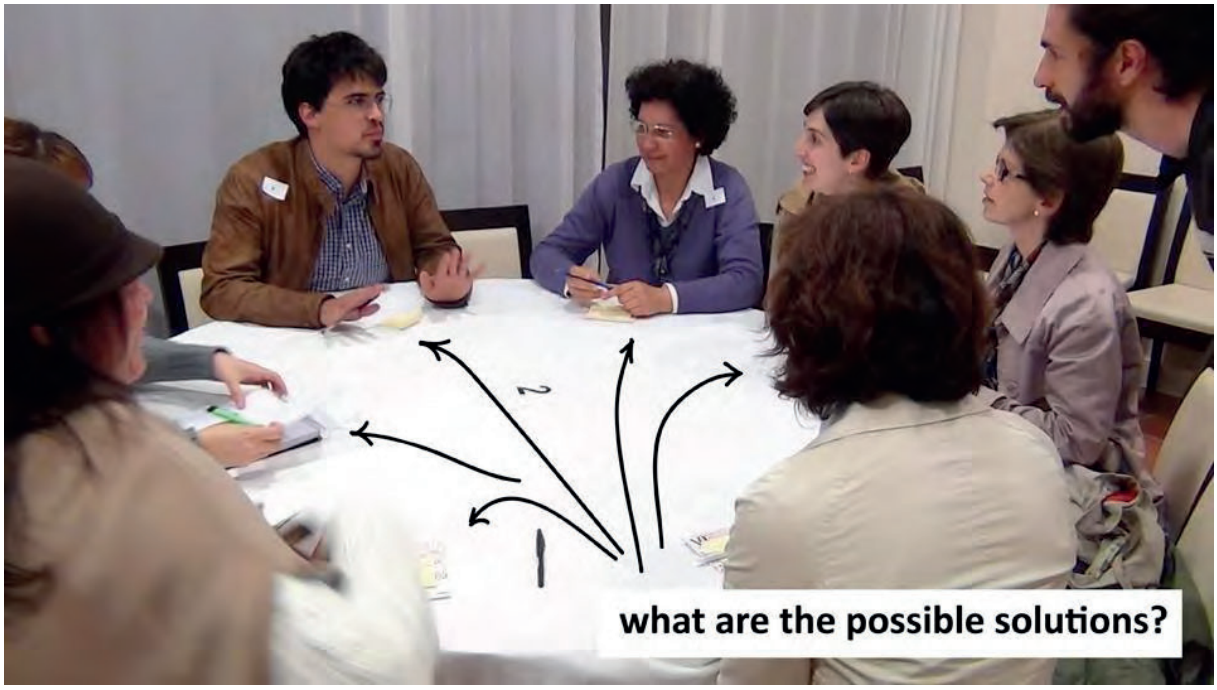


Figure 4 "World Café". Participants were divided into groups of 6-7 people with the challenge of responding to the problems raised in a previous meeting. Photo by Viva Cidade, commented by authors.

Sharing and changing: The final proposal was the transformation of a space in a small and cosy common area, with street furniture; a wall made of tiles with caricatures of the residents and a vertical garden (Fig. 8). A picnic was also organized by the participants in the chosen location, where the proposal was presented to a wider community. Displayed on panels and in a large format, the proposal was open to criticism and to new proposals (Fig. 5). Before the intervention two more meetings were held in order to develop co-creation strategies to seek for the necessary resources. Around 20 contributors, including local businesses and patrons had provided material resources and services needed for the construction. Most of the materials were recycled from civil construction activities.

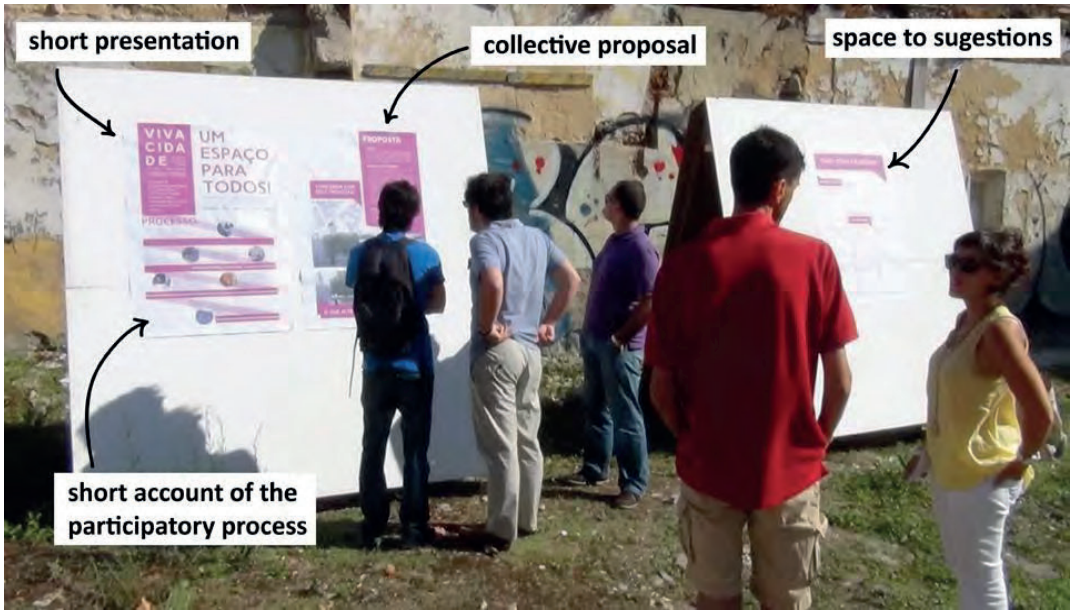


Figure 5 Public exhibition of the participatory process and proposal for the common space. Photo by Viva Cidade, commented by authors.

Second stage

This stage was carried out during two weeks through extensive local collaborations, including the following activities:

Open Lab: A small abandoned house near the selected space was provided by the owner and turned into a temporary open lab (Fig. 6).

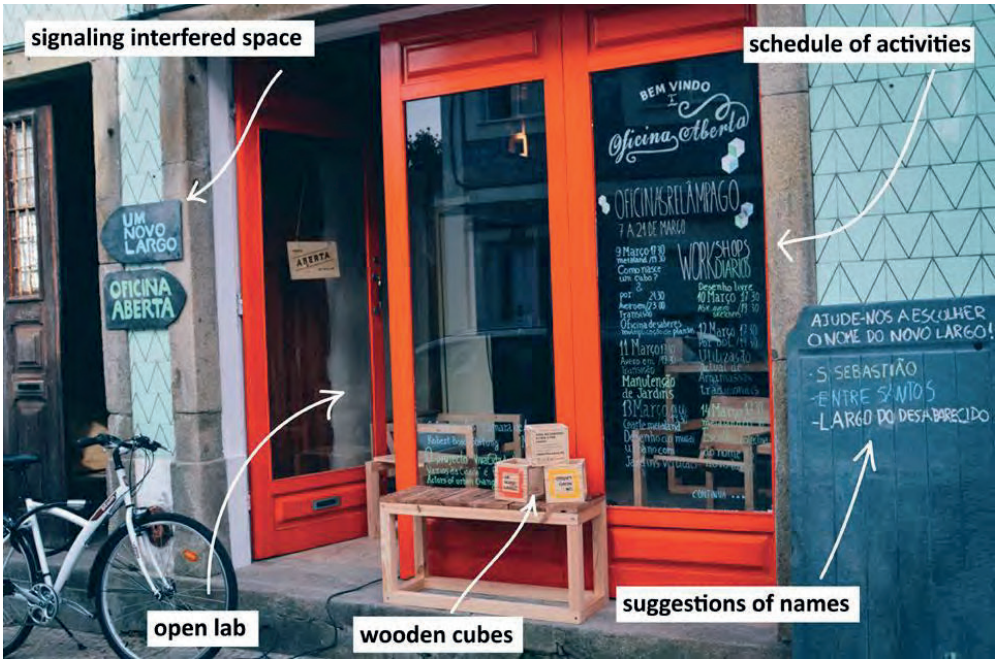


Figure 6 Open lab: Space collectively refurbished for the purpose of carrying out workshop activities, storing materials and tools, in addition to functioning as a meeting place. Photo by Viva City, interfered by authors.

Making-learning activities: During three weeks, beyond the initial participants, civil organizations, artistic groups and students were involved voluntarily in different creative workshops and interactive activities.

Street furniture: This workshop began with the construction of wooden cubes that were distributed around the neighbourhood with the intention "to extend a literal and easily understandable invitation to build collectively" (Surwitto-Hahn and Schwegmann 2015). After that, the environment developed through the production of benches and tables, consequently starting to build up the environment. The first prototypes were exposed making it possible for the public to comment, replicate and further stylize (Fig. 7).



Figure 7 Collaborative construction of street furniture done through a mutual learning process. Photo by Viva Cidade, commented by authors.



Figure 8 Final event of the project with the built physical space. Photo by authors.

Third stage

This stage represents the real effects of the project. According to both the observations and interviews, the area gained new social relations and affections by the residents that live around the space. Some residents feel in charge of the space to take care of the community garden, furniture, cleaning and maintenance. The space and surroundings gained a certain visibility after the project was implemented with the support of the local media, being verified the constant use of the new space by people living inside and outside the neighbourhood.

Results and Discussion

Engagement: Designing participation

The category of engagement is seen in developed methods and practices working to transcend enclosure and open to the involvement of new commoners, as well as its effects in the power dynamics established in the decision making process. Thus, engagement is analysed in spaces between the community and the project proposal; and among the members of the proponent team.

The interviews revealed in the initial phase a conflict of generations due to the strong disbelief of older residents participating in the project. They did not believe in it as it was being driven by younger people who also led its implementation. To break this barrier the strategy was to gain the confidence of some elderly people and more communicative residents in the neighbourhood. Mapping and discussing at round tables, having coffee

together and providing a more playful setting made it possible for the participants to play with the territory and develop a critical view of the neighbourhood.

The interaction between the three social sectors (public, private and NGO) enabled constant negotiations of conflicting interests, concessions and understandings. In spite of the fact that the municipality provided human resources to work in the project, there was a constant effort by the project promoters to legitimize the project in the eyes of the public institution, as well as to deal with the strong bureaucratic pressure imposed by the local government. Thus, the representative of the public sector in the project team participated as a mediator between the project proposal and the City Hall interests.

The fact that the chosen space was a City Hall property interfered in the effectiveness of the commoning process. After the end of the meetings with the participants, in which the project proposal was discussed, co-created and approved by them, eight months passed until the start of its implementation. The main reason for that was the delayed bureaucratic process of the “approval” of the final proposal by the City Hall. After so many months, the project was finally “authorized” by the institution mainly through the pressure imposed by the Robert Bosh Foundation, which was the foreigner funding institution. Finally, the temporary space proposed by the project was “approved” as a "public space of the municipality".

These evidences reflected some distrust of the public sector when facing a more horizontal and decentralized participatory process, which is related with a “common space” rather than with a “public space”. According to Stavrides(2016), while the concept of “public space” is officially introduced as a space for everyone within the rules imposed by top-down decisions, “common space” is related to the common good which is managed by a group of people through more decentralized decision-making processes. Thus, in common spaces participation becomes a dynamic process of collaboration between different capacities in which horizontal and decentralized models of participation are constantly tested. Thus, the negotiation process that occurred during the project Viva Cidade revealed the unbalance in terms of decision-making processes, in which the NGO and the local enterprise had little power in the ultimate decision comparing with the municipality.

This change of meaning led by the City Hall is an evidence of its resistance in understanding and accepting commoning as a resourceful strategy in dealing with areas of the city that are in a process of rapid programmatic changes. Therefore, instead of making public this experience, the municipality strived to communicate this project to a larger audience as a top-down achievement led by its representatives. Indeed, this project was categorized to fit into an array of social sensitive projects of the municipality, which became instrumental for the municipality, not only feeding the list of social achievements but also reinforcing its political agenda to a wider public. This fact removed some of the potentiality of the project to promote changes, losing its authenticity and autonomy.

Finally, this particular project reveals a critical point in the process for commoning mediated by design when it has to deal with different levels of decision. At this point, design runs the

risk of ending in an imaginary construction of a false democratic consensus between the involved parties (Mouffe 2013). Instead of performing a limited role of mediation, the design practice as a "democratic experiment" could facilitate socio-material conditions for controversial issues, making "things" public in direct engagement (Binder et al. 2015). Thus, in this particular project the matters of concern for the activation of direct participation were hidden and smoothened through the traditional “democratic” process. Consequently, this compromised the effectiveness of the commoning process.

Collaboration: Collaborative aesthetic experience

The category of collaboration was identified by joint efforts for the construction of the temporary space through collaborative aesthetic experience or the “aesthetic experience” for commoning. The aesthetic experience in Heidegger (1977) takes place through sensory appropriation of the artistic object by the observer who gives meaning to the artwork. Thus, the basis of its existence is addressed in the dynamic interplay between the object, the creator and the observer. This notion can be associated with the "poietic activity" of design practice, directly linked to its effects in the social reality. The understanding of the notion of "poietic activity" in design can be expanded as the aesthetic that activates the participation of individuals in a collective environment following a change of meanings (Carlsson 2010) or interfering in the established subjective structures (Guattari 2005) building new worldviews and changing individual habits.

Thus, assembling existing resources activated the aesthetic experience in the case study. Since the project budget was limited, it was necessary to look for contributors who could donate their working time or material resources that would make the project to happen. This was made possible through the activation of the networks of each person involved. The local residents were able to negotiate with the owner of the space to temporarily provide an "open lab"; a neighbour temporarily provided electricity for the space; the municipality managed the donation of wasted construction materials; and the local entrepreneurs have got support from local businesses. Moreover, the implementation of the proposal as an "open lab" was also important for the activation of the space. The maintenance of the space was made collectively, adding new meanings to the place. It functioned as a living laboratory harbouring constant exchange of knowledge through interaction in workshops and through informal conversations. Finally, the construction of the wooden furniture put in place the final proposal to create a cosy common area. Rather than providing functional objects, relations and feelings were shared among the participants through the production.

Thus, in the collaborative aesthetic experience of Viva Cidade project, the three elements highlighted by Heidegger (1977) - object, creator and observer - merge into a given space and time thought the shared "poietic activity" (Carlsson 2010), presented as a spatial experience that seeks meaning through the process of mutual making and learning among individuals with different knowledge. The management of scarce resources offered capabilities of urban resilience to the participants, which is one of the aspects highlighted by the commoning processes as way to less neoliberal economic dependences (Stavrides 2016).

However, no design strategies were identified to promote more effective commoning in the neighbourhood. This weaknesses of the project were identified at the moment of construction of the space, in which all the practical parts of the project were in the hands of a younger group of people with specialized artistic and design skills, without the involvement of neighbourhood residents in coordination and leadership activities. The concern about the "beauty" of the final space overlaps the collaborative aesthetic experience in mutual exchange of experiences. This was conditioned by the concentration of practical activities of the project in only three weeks, putting great expectations and demands on the coordination of the project. This meant that many activities were not completed leading to criticism from some residents, who felt dependent on some of the experts who were no longer there at the last stages of the project. These evidences are related with the third empowerment category.

Empowerment: "Designing for commoning?"

The temporary spaces produced by the project can be considered as a "threshold space" towards commoning, which are attempted to control the inherent potentialities of crossing, connecting while separating and separating while connecting (Stavrides 2016). The new creative commons emerging today provide wide possibilities, developing beyond geographic limitations into virtual networks, penetrating in commodities and institutionalized spaces, producing non-finalized and fragmented commons, managing new ways to operationalize the urban system (Reimer 2011).

In this sense, from the perspective of physical space was observed that the space was used by the neighbours to place traditional parties, as well as to attend the necessity of having a meeting place in that area. However, it was observed that only two residents took the initiative to take care of the space in the first months after its implementation. Many design efforts were identified to establish collaborations with bottom-up initiatives of social and cultural organizations of the city of Aveiro, despite the lack of strategy that could focus on the residents that live around the built space, which would continue to give life to the place and would allow the production of commons between them in an autonomous way.

Although the materiality of the space was temporary, the collective experience was disseminated by people who participated in the development of other spaces in the city. According to the collected evidences, the establishment of a social relationships and affection for the neighbourhood was observed within the community. Beyond this specific community, it was verified that this project inspired other specific measures in the city, such as the integration of new participatory strategies by a local business association that aims to activate the local market in one of the most central city streets. The methodology of the project has been integrated in urban strategies of the City Hall of Aveiro in order to engage the residents in future decision-making processes. The university has been producing academic design projects, which investigate the participatory processes for social innovation in Portugal.

Conclusion

This paper presents a qualitative analysis of an experimental, interdisciplinary and inter-sectorial design project of co-creation of a temporary space in a small neighbourhood of the city of Aveiro, Portugal. The study was based on the concept of common and commoning, suggesting in the first part of the text a preliminary analytical map of design participation for commoning, in which the elements of commons were visualized *(resource, community and negotiation)* and its relationship with co-creation approaches developed by design research *(diffuse creativity, disruptive aesthetic and democratic innovation)*. The mapping has resulted in three categories of analysis presented in the case study: *engagement, collaboration and empowerment*. It is argued that the design practices for commoning require temporary spaces that allow dynamic collaborations though negotiations among different capacities within the community and outside of it. Thus, the aim of this paper was to analyse how the participation was designed for commoning in this specific case study.

In this study five further aspects have been highlighted. First, the notion of commons and commoning in design helped clarify the value of abilities developed through making things together, in which new forms of communication and stages of negotiation are constantly tested forward to respond matters of concerns in participation processes. Second, the aesthetic dimension of design applied to social dynamics allowed for an understanding of participation as a collaborative experience process through learning, teaching and doing together. Third, the negotiation process revealed the power inherent in urban territorial relations, especially in the ways in which institutions and civil society position themselves. Fourth, the project also identified the risks of participatory design projects and more horizontal and decentralized participatory culture when applied from top-down. Finally, the autonomy of participatory processes depends on extensive interdisciplinary collaboration. Rather than facilitating shared decision-making processes, design practices have the role of articulating new forms of emerging public matters of concern that influence and change people's life.

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